

Speaker 1 [00:00:03] Ah okay, it started. So let me begin. We are curious about your views on romantic relationships. We believe your experiences will contribute to our project. Before we start, is it okay for you to accept this interview?

Speaker 2 [00:00:20] Sure, it's okay.

Speaker 1 [00:00:23] Then let's start. How old are you?

Speaker 2 [00:00:27] [31-35].

Speaker 1 [00:00:29] How long have you been with your partner?

Speaker 2 [00:00:33] We had a friendship before, which then turned into a relationship. Including the friendship, it's been [1-5] years, but as a romantic relationship, it's been nearly [1-5] years.

Speaker 1 [00:00:48] Do you have any children?

Speaker 2 [00:00:51] Not biological, but I have stepchildren. Can I mention the names you talked to before? Sure, you can. He has [1-5] children from his previous marriage. I'm not the biological mother, but we are like a family.

Speaker 1 [00:01:08] Okay. So, who do you live with?

Speaker 2 [00:01:09] I live alone.

Speaker 1 [00:01:14] What is your main source of income?

Speaker 2 [00:01:16] I am a [occupation].

Speaker 1 [00:01:22] How would you like to refer to your partner? Boyfriend, spouse, lover?

Speaker 2 [00:01:27] Let's say lover.

Speaker 1 [00:01:34] Can you tell me the story of how you met and how your relationship started?

[Portion Redacted]

Speaker 1 [00:03:03] How would you compare the quality of your relationship to your friends' relationships?

Speaker 2 [00:03:10] How do I assess my relationship? If we look at it from every angle, our relationship seems more mature to me in every sense.

Speaker 1 [00:03:29] Could you elaborate on that?

Speaker 2 [00:03:33] The way we experience emotions, it's not just about saying "I love (sevmek) you" or "I am in love (aşk)" but our skill to turn it into a living practice is much more beautiful. Our shared space feels very fruitful, and even if there are problems, the beauty of our shared space makes us overlook them. When compared to other relationships, it makes me feel like I have something very beautiful and want to protect it.

Speaker 1 [00:04:24] I understand.

Speaker 2 [00:04:27] The feeling is that it's a more mature, grounded, and special relationship. It feels like experiencing something from a movie in real life, which makes one very happy.

Speaker 1 [00:04:49] How many romantic relationships have you had in the past?

Speaker 2 [00:04:54] I haven't had many relationships like this. I've had people I liked, but it didn't turn into a relationship. This mostly happened during university years. For me, love (sevgi) is a very deep connection, and I believe it's a very private area that shouldn't be shared with everyone. So, this is my first significant relationship.

Speaker 1 [00:05:38] How would you compare your current relationship to your past experiences?

Speaker 2 [00:05:43] What I felt before was less significant. It was more about having a crush, not truly knowing the person. It was more about the idea of love rather than the reality. Now, it's about experiencing and living love in a practical, mutual way, which is completely different. In other words, I can taste the unity of the mind and the heart here. You know, if you define what a wife is, I am actually in it right now and this satisfies me a lot. I can't really make any comparison.

Speaker 1 [00:06:50] What makes a relationship high-quality for you?

Speaker 2 [00:06:57] For me, what makes a relationship high-quality is feeling understood, the sense of sincerity, and the feeling of being a whole. When "I" and "you" become "we," that deep sense of connection shows the quality of a relationship.

Speaker 1 [00:07:19] So, for you, a strong relationship is one where you feel understood, contains sincerity, and has a sense of wholeness. How do you feel understood in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:07:34] How do I feel understood? Feeling valued and healed by the presence of my partner shows the quality of the relationship. Even if we have disagreements, the way we communicate with respect and care shows the quality of the relationship.

Speaker 1 [00:08:40] When was the last time you felt understood, felt the sincerity, and the sense of wholeness in your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:08:49] I actually feel this every day. I felt it this morning, yesterday, and the day before. It's rare that I feel misunderstood. Sometimes, it might be because of our own state of mind, but generally, I feel understood.

Speaker 1 [00:09:29] What are the most important things in a relationship for you?

Speaker 2 [00:09:34] Loyalty is important. Feeling that the person next to you is your partner, being able to look at things as a whole, and thinking about each other equally are important. Listening is also very important because people want to feel understood and heard. Love (sevgi), loyalty, and respect are crucial.

Speaker 1 [00:10:22] What is love (aşk) to you?

Speaker 2 [00:10:25] For me, love (aşk)'s definition can change based on experiences. It's about having both mental and emotional connection. When these synchronize, it feels like a seed of warmth in your heart that keeps blooming. Love (aşk) can involve both joy and pain, but it always leads to growth and enrichment.

Speaker 1 [00:11:25] How important is love (aşk) in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:11:29] I think it's very important. If you ask me to rate it between 1 and 10, I would say 9. Giving it a 10 might be too ambitious.

Speaker 1 [00:11:41] Why a 9?

Speaker 2 [00:11:44] Because when you have both mental and emotional connection, it forms the basis for understanding each other. It supports personal growth and creates a good foundation for a relationship. Even in negative situations, it helps to heal and improve the relationship.

Speaker 1 [00:12:55] How do you know your partner loves (sevmek) you?

Speaker 2 [00:12:59] Just looking into his eyes is enough. You can feel the warmth from the heart. It's like how children can sense genuine love. It's not just about words, but the sincerity and warmth that come from the heart.

Speaker 1 [00:13:36] What are the challenges in your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:13:42] We do have different personalities, but living with these differences is beautiful. Our challenges mostly come from external factors. We've gone through some tough times, but we've managed to get through them.

Speaker 1 [00:14:24] Do you and your partner argue?

Speaker 2 [00:14:28] We don't have very intense arguments, but we do have discussions. Sometimes we might not be in the right mood, but we usually resolve things easily. It depends on external stress, but we don't argue frequently.

Speaker 1 [00:15:26] What are these arguments usually about?

Speaker 2 [00:15:32] They are often about simple things, like misunderstandings or small annoyances. For example, I might be in a sensitive mood and misinterpret something he says. But we usually resolve these quickly.

Speaker 1 [00:16:33] How do you resolve these arguments?

Speaker 2 [00:16:37] We talk a lot and reflect on things. Sometimes we take a break and then discuss it calmly. Just looking into each other's eyes can be enough to resolve things.

Speaker 1 [00:17:05] Besides talking, what other ways do you maintain your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:17:14] By not overreacting to issues and thinking positively. We try to focus on resolving things beautifully. It's about not making a big deal out of problems.

Speaker 1 [00:17:51] Do you think this relationship is good for you?

Speaker 2 [00:17:55] Yes, I feel it's very healing and good for me. I'm glad I have it in spite of everything

Speaker 1 [00:18:05] Why do you think so?

Speaker 2 [00:18:09] It feels like it was always meant to be. Love (sevgi) is very precious to me, and I'm not someone who falls in love easily. But this relationship developed naturally. I feel so whole. It's an area where I feel very nourished and I feel, how can I say, healed. It doesn't tire me. I mean, I can actually describe even the difficulties with beauty.

Speaker 1 [00:18:50] Has this relationship changed you?

Speaker 2 [00:18:54] Yes, it has. I used to be more impulsive, but I've learned to be more thoughtful and strategic. My partner is very intelligent and has an analytical mind, and he taught me to approach things more calmly. I made peace with myself. I've also learned to value myself more. I mean, for example, we are studying together right now. We have common goals. We are currently studying at university together, but we are not doing it under compulsion, we love to produce a joint product. I also learned to produce with him.

Speaker 1 [00:20:08] Has your partner changed during this relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:20:12] Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:20:13] In what way?

Speaker 2 [00:20:21] He has learned to be more hopeful and positive. Despite his past problems, he's learned to look forward and be optimistic. He also feels understood and supported.

Speaker 1 [00:21:17] Do you feel safe in this relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:21:21] Yes, I do.

Speaker 1 [00:21:23] Can you elaborate on that?

Speaker 2 [00:21:26] Looking at our previous discussions, it's clear why I feel safe. The sense of security and trust is very strong. It's like a safety net that makes me feel very secure.

Speaker 1 [00:22:07] I will show you some questions from a scale. If you can't read them, I will read them out loud.

Speaker 2 [00:22:17] Sure.

Speaker 1 [00:22:21] My partner generally listens to me. On a scale from 1 to 9, where 1 is not true at all and 9 is completely true, what would your answer be?

Speaker 2 [00:22:26] Considering what I've said before, I'd say between 7 and 8. Let's say 8.

Speaker 1 [00:22:52] My partner is generally sensitive to my needs. Again, on a scale from 1 to 9.

Speaker 2 [00:23:02] If I had to choose one, I'd say 9.

Speaker 1 [00:23:07] So you gave 8 for my partner generally listens to me. Why 8 and not 7 or 9?

Speaker 2 [00:23:18] Because 9 would imply perfection, and we do have moments of stress where we might miss something. If there were a 7.5, I would have chosen that. It's about balancing expectations with reality.

Speaker 1 [00:23:47] You gave 9 for my partner is generally sensitive to my needs. Can you give a concrete example of when this happened recently?

Speaker 2 [00:24:00] For example, I don't have a perfect relationship with my mother. When I hear something hurtful, he immediately supports me. He helps me replace negative thoughts with positive ones, which shows his sensitivity and care.

Speaker 1 [00:24:55] I hope you don't mind me asking this. If it's a sensitive topic, please let me know. We want to know about your physical intimacy as a couple. How often do you have sexual relations these days?

Speaker 2 [00:25:10] This is very sensitive.

Speaker 1 [00:25:12] Okay, we can skip that. How satisfied are you with your relationship overall?

Speaker 2 [00:25:22] I'm very satisfied.

Speaker 1 [00:25:33] On a scale from 1 to 7, where 1 is completely dissatisfied and 7 is completely satisfied, what would you rate it?

Speaker 2 [00:25:44] As a relationship, I would say 7.

Speaker 1 [00:25:51] On a scale from 0 to 10, what would you rate it?

Speaker 2 [00:25:59] Between 0 and 10, I would give it a 10.

Speaker 1 [00:26:04] Why did you give it a 10?

Speaker 2 [00:26:12] Because your phrasing suggested "completely satisfied," which fits my feelings. Our communication, bond, and the fact that we can do many things together make it very fulfilling.

Speaker 1 [00:26:45] We are almost done. Let me summarize what we discussed. [Portion Redacted] Compared to your friends' relationships, you see your relationship as more mature. Mental, emotional, and spiritual connections are important to you. You believe a high-quality relationship involves feeling understood, sincerity, and a sense of wholeness. Love (aşk)'s definition can change based on experiences, but it generally involves mental and emotional unity. You resolve conflicts quickly, either by talking or by reducing their impact. You feel that this relationship is healing and fulfilling. You believe it has positively changed both you and your partner. You are completely satisfied with your relationship. Is there anything else you would like to add?

Speaker 2 [00:28:16] About the changes, I realized while talking that I don't try to change him into what I want. Our changes are more about mutual growth. I just wanted to clarify that.

Speaker 1 [00:28:45] Now we are done with our study. I want to ask how we should handle the data. This is a research project, and we want to be as transparent as possible. Which option would you prefer for sharing the data? The first option is to share excerpts of the interview without any identifiable information. The second option is to share more detailed, anonymized excerpts. The second option has a slight risk that someone who knows you might recognize you, but no sensitive information will be shared. Which option do you prefer?

Speaker 2 [00:29:46] I prefer the anonymized excerpts.

Speaker 1 [00:29:50] So you choose the first option. Is that okay?

Speaker 2 [00:29:50] Yes.

